of the Soviet factor increased in India (after the signing of the 1971 Indo-Soviet Treaty of Friendship and Cooperation), Kabul too became dependent on military and economic support from Moscow as the two factions of the PDPA came under Soviet protection.[58] Ever since its inception in 1968, India's external intelligence agency, the Research and Analysis Wing (R&AW) run by R N Kao, developed close links with the Afghan secret services, the Khadamat-e Aetla'at-e Dawlati (KhAD) and the Soviet intelligence agency, the Komitet Gosudarstvennoy Bezopasnosti (KGB).[59] Supplementing New Delhi and Kabul's tilt towards Moscow was Iraq's interest in this security complex in the mid-1970s.

Like India and Pakistan, Iraq and Iran were bitter rivals. And similar to Pakistan and Iran's cooperation, India and Iraq developed a close economic, political, and military relationship that was personified by the excellent rapport between Saddam Hussein and Indira Gandhi (especially after 1979).[60] Arming Baloch separatists on the Iranian side was in Iraq's interest, and on Pakistan's side in India's strategic interest. Kabul for its part, to avoide a standoff with Iran, communicated to Tehran that it supported Baloch separatism only in 'former colonial areas, not those living in "legally constituted territories"'.[61] As a junior level Indian intelligence official actively involved in these operations, says, 'we gave the Baloch everything, from money to guns, during the 1970s, everything'.[62] In fact, the watershed moment that led to the NAP government's dismissal in 1973 was the discovery of an arms cache in the Iraqi Embassy in Islamabad that convinced Bhutto of an armed revolt by the Baloch and Pashtun separatists with support from Iraq and India.[63] The Wali- Khan-led NAP had formed a secret militant wing called the *Pashtun Zalmay* (it included Baloch militants too) that was in active contact with Kabul, as well as the Indian and Iraqi missions in Afghanistan.[64] It was responsible for a series of bomb blasts and subversive activities inside Pakistan. Iraq had allowed the BPLF to openly run its operations from an office in Baghdad.[65] In return, the Shah of Iran, Mohammad Reza Pahlavi, provided military support to Pakistan in order to crush the Baloch insurgency.[66] The intensity of these political fissures is reflected in a secret letter sent by Ram D. Sathe (then a senior Indian diplomat who would go on to become foreign secretary) to India's ambassador in Tehran in March 1975, that 'it will be a few more days before the Iranians stridently back the Pakistanis [on